



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 2

ALABAMA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Alabama's family courts and child-welfare system.

52

ALABAMA FAMILIES ON RECORD · 61
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 14 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING
TIME

REPORT GENERATED

MAY 5, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED

24 OF 67

COMPILED BY

MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

ALABAMA AT A GLANCE.

Across 52 Alabama families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 61 49 of 52 families reported child counts	MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN \$86,000 median across 21 families reporting 3+ categories	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 14 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 42.3% 28.8% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 52	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.2	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 49 of 52	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 24

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Alabama families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF ALABAMA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

Expense Category	Responses	Median	Mean	Total Reported
Attorney Fees	28	\$11,650	\$24,944	\$698,442
Lost Wages	27	\$27,000	\$272,597	\$7,360,115
Other Court Fees	15	\$1,000	\$6,103	\$91,550
Therapy / Evaluations	18	\$1,750	\$3,606	\$64,900
Reunification Services	13	\$0	\$1,002	\$13,030
GAL Fees	19	\$1,000	\$2,371	\$45,050
Asset Loss ¹	19	\$18,000	—	—
Median Family Burden (21 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	\$86,000	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least \$1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$18,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Category	Median months lost	Mean months lost	Total across all families
Median months lost	14	1.2 yrs	
Mean months lost	40	3.3 yrs	
Total across all families			1,152 96 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · ALABAMA

Most families documenting in Alabama are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		19	37%
Not provided		13	25%
Case closed: within last 2 years		8	15%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		7	13%
Active case: progress being made		2	4%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		21	40%
Family Court Only		16	31%
Unknown		9	17%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		3	6%
Family Court		1	2%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		19	37%
5 – 10 years		8	15%
3 – 5 years		5	10%
Over 10 years		5	10%
0-1 years		4	8%

CUSTODY STATUS

Visitation Only		16	31%
No Contact / Total Loss of Access		16	31%
Full Custody		8	15%
50/50 Joint		3	6%
Not Applicable		3	6%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Mobile		3	6%
Houston		3	6%
Autauga		3	6%
Madison		2	4%
Baldwin		2	4%
Talladega		2	4%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		12	23%
Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		11	21%
Other: (Short answer)		7	13%
False Allegations / Coached Claims		5	10%
High Conflict Divorce		3	6%

04 PARENT VOICES — ALABAMA

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Alabama comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



Destroyed my family and my relationship with my children who I practically raised on my own for 14 years. Caused trauma, anxiety, PTSD

— BRANDY

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Estranged me (the mother) from my kids who were legally kidnapped to the other side of the country in Canada in 2020. Severe CPTSD. My kids all developed depression, insomnia, anxiety and behavioural issues. I have been battling a serious illness (breast cancer) since 2018 with [...]

— ALABAMA PARENT · JACKIE

MORE VOICES FROM ALABAMA

Threatening me with jail time unless I gave into the ex at court. All because I would not give my children to him during my parenting time. Simply because the parenting coordinator and GAL said I should. The judge wants to set an example. You cannot bring your phone on that [...]

— RACHEL

The system has lacked their due diligence to protect my children from the psychological abuse from their father.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The family court system fully showed me why the government should have 0 say so or hand in how YOUR CHILD OR CHILDREN ARE parented.

— JESSICA

Destroyed our family my son passed and we have not seen our granddaughter since she didn't even get to come to her dad's funeral

— KELLI

Family court has destroyed all consistency and stability for my children. We do not feel safe.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

A system ment to bring families together did nothing but traumatically rip mine apart.

— FELICIA

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



The system has proven to my children and I that they are not there to provide support, protection and reunification. They very boldly stand in your face and laugh while doing the complete opposite due to financial motives. They have stolen the first two years of my children's [...]

— MARY

They falsely accused me of child abuse and took two of my children. Then I had another one and they took her. DHR ended up giving me back the youngest and are making me go to family court against my Dad and stepmom for my other two. I just recently went back to court for the [...]

— LATOYA

We lost our grandson at 15 months, who we had raised since birth. Our granddaughter was born addicted and taken into state custody at birth. We were ready and able to take them both. Falsified drug tests on the DCS service provider. I paid for a hair follicle test and proved [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Jefferson County GAL was corrupt and dismissed drug usage of parent given primary custody. She also falsified previous agreement signed by court child support was waived and I am now paying child support with arrears. Jefferson co family court is infiltrated with corrupt bias [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has destroyed my family and our belief in justice, hope, and humanity.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They took tragedy as an opportunity to create lasting trauma my family and I still have not fully recovered from. We haven't even had a ceremony to grieve our lost son yet because we're still trying to recover from the disaster that destroyed everything.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My children have been alienated from me.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They physically mentally and emotionally abused me and my child and financially took everything from me by my mental stage I have not been able to work since I cannot focus on that when I was focusing trying to figure out why there's taking my child in the first place

— JODIE

Jefferson county has shattered me and left me without a voice all while covering up someone is who abusive and has a criminal record and our children have begged to not go back to him.

— ASHLEE

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



They've taken children who already lost their parents and put them in dangerous situations when they have a loving grandmother who would give her life to protect and love them.

— STEPHANIE

Left me isolated from every one and mentally debilitated me with phyco report says 60% out of a 100 is my custody n dcp issue

— CLOEY

They have ruined my life, making my daughter feel unsafe because we can't be together.

— MEGAN

ASTNGU. AMTNGU. This bond between us can't be broken, I will be here don't you cry. You'll be in my Heart. ☐ Always.

— HEATHER

CPS and family court trafficked my children to the pedophile father and erased me, a safe, protective mother from my daughter's lives. I have a gag order and am not allowed to speak about my case. But I still do however I can.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The court allowed my sister-in-law to walk in there and say I was messed up on drugs leaving my two year old defend for herself. I never got served properly. My neighbor found it in her mailbox, but I still had to hand my children over only two of them, though I got to keep the [...]

— CRYSANI

Took the life of my husband, almost mine and alienated maternal side of the family, unjust actions to terminate my rights. They have taken both of my daughters parents from her.

— HEIDI

Not allowing for me make contact with my daughter, enabling my ex's bad behavior, by allowing her to hide my daughter from me, not telling if she's okay or not, just dead silence

— TERRY

This system has absolutely tore my family apart. I now deal with trauma and will need counseling and I have my baby back but I feel I have to put cameras in every room in my home because of what I've been through with these allegations .

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

If you wanted to destroy a powerful woman... you wouldn't go after her directly. You'd go after her heart. Her children. Her sanity. This is family court and it's destroying the heart and soul of our children

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has failed my two granddaughters.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Thankfully my family court battle started when my daughter was a baby and her last visit with her father was 2019. But the fear of the Judge and how everything went down was enough to last a lifetime. I hate anyone going through family court. It's so unfair.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My son suffers from always worrying about DHR coming to get him. They have tried for 14 years to take my son. I told them they wasn't getting mine and that it was harassment after so many visits. I told them it wasn't a crime to be poor as long as my child had his needs met.

— TRACY

It has showed us that no matter how good a person you are, or how right you are, there are people in positions of power who will gleefully make you the scum of the earth in the eyes of the court. It doesn't matter how insane another person is or how many crazy things they do, if [...]

— JASON

I am terrified to let my child out of my site. Every single little mark I am documenting it all. I cptsd and am having to go to therapy for this. I have nightmares of this even after 3 yrs. I have a hard time letting anyone visit us.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Some days I sit back and realize... the worst thing that has ever happened in my life barely exists in anyone else's. My child was taken away. My world stopped. My heart broke in a way that will never fully heal. But the world didn't stop. People kept laughing. Kept posting. Kept [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

Ruined everything I made.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

How can any person decide alone who is allowed to be a mother regardless. My momma told me at 17, pregnant, “you don’t get to choose when you’re ready to be a mother.” That I’ll never forget. This is a bond that cannot be broken. Why bash fathers or mother who WANT to be there. [...]

— HEATHER

35 Alabama parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 35 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — ALABAMA

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Alabama families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

Estranged me (the mother) from my kids who were legally kidnapped to the other side of the country in Canada in 2020. Severe CPTSD. My kids all developed depression, insomnia, anxiety and behavioural issues. I have been battling a serious illness (breast cancer) since 2018 with a second occurrence that happened this past October. Severe poverty, loss, destitution, loss of civil liberties (the government suspended my drivers licence because I couldn't pay outrageous child support- my parents had to drive me to chemotherapy and life-saving medical appointments). My income is long term disability and I get \$2150/month. My court order for child support is over \$600/month. He won't let it go. I'm in arrears of over \$40,000. It's still being tallied up by the month. Any income and credits from GST or other government rebates get garnished and automatically go to him. Severe financial and economic post-separation abuse. Evidence of physical and all other abuse during marriage which I presented to the courts was blatantly ignored & swept under the rug. He remarried and the income between him and his spouse is at least \$350,000/year. They tried to bury me alive and still are. Fraud, maliciousness. Contempt of court. Not providing his tax returns for the last 5 years. In the same week I found out I had survived my first occurrence with breast cancer, the ex threatened me with a mobility application to move my kids cross-country. They gave him everything, I lost everything because I was too weak to represent myself and couldn't afford a lawyer. Legal Aid in my province is filled with incompetence and negligence - nobody would help me. In fact, the lawyers from legal aid took

— JACKIE (1/2)

advantage of my vulnerabilities and purposely dragged me, one for an entire year, she did absolutely nothing but gave me false hope. It's really unbelievable and sadistic. I have literally paid with my life and my kids lives because I made the choice to get married. Alberta Canada is festering with some of the most corrupt judges in the Western world. What happened to me and is still happening is absolutely criminal.

— JACKIE (2/2)

Destroyed my family and my relationship with my children who I practically raised on my own for 14 years. Caused trauma, anxiety, PTSD

— BRANDY

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Threatening me with jail time unless I gave into the ex at court. All because I would not give my children to him during my parenting time. Simply because the parenting coordinator and GAL said I should. The judge wants to set an example. You cannot bring your phone on that floor of the court house. 10 years of abuse, 4 years of battling in the courts to keep my children and this is where we are. My sons will end up with a vindictive manipulator and the people who enable him.

— RACHEL

The system has lacked their due diligence to protect my children from the psychological abuse from their father.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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They falsely accused me of child abuse and took two of my children. Then I had another one and they took her. DHR ended up giving me back the youngest and are making me go to family court against my Dad and stepmom for my other two. I just recently went back to court for the other two but they are making me prove something called the McClendon Standard which is only used in Alabama. I wish I could speak on this

— LATOYA

We lost our grandson at 15 months, who we had raised since birth. Our granddaughter was born addicted and taken into state custody at birth. We were ready and able to take them both. Falsified drug tests on the DCS service provider. I paid for a hair follicle test and proved them erroneous. I am currently in a federal case against these state actors Tate and Davis for denying my rights to visit and gain custody. The judge was recused and changed. Our new judge took 10 days to return the children to our sole custody

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— CRYSAW

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05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Ruined everything I made.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

How can any person decide alone who is allowed to be a mother regardless. My momma told me at 17, pregnant, "you don't get to choose when you're ready to be a mother." That I'll never forget. This is a bond that cannot be broken. Why bash fathers or mother who WANT to be there. Why not bash the ones who DONT FIGHT.

— HEATHER

35 full approved Alabama comments are included in this appendix.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Alabama report comes from Alabama respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Alabama — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 52 Alabama families reporting here are not the universe of Alabama families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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